

# FARMING, HISTORY OF

F



TEN THOUSAND YEARS AGO, the first farmers began to grow crops and breed animals for food. Before that, nomadic hunter-gatherers fed on berries, plants, and wild beasts they encountered on their travels. With the emergence of farming, however, people were able to produce a reliable food supply, and to settle permanently in one place, giving rise to the world's earliest civilizations in Mesopotamia, Egypt, India, and China. Farming methods continued to evolve slowly until, in the 18th century, a so-called Agricultural Revolution led to dramatic changes. Since then, farming has become more mechanized and feeds ever greater numbers of people.

## Agricultural revolution

From about 1750, a series of major changes ushered in the era of modern farming. Key developments included large-scale farming, the intensive breeding of livestock, and the improvement of a number of agricultural techniques – such as four-course crop rotation – all of which were first developed in Britain.

### Selective breeding

Robert Bakewell (1725–95), the fifth Duke of Bedford (1765–1802), and other British stock breeders during the Agricultural Revolution, used selective breeding on their farms and estates to develop larger, healthier animals, such as cattle, goats, sheep, and turkeys, with a higher milk or meat yield. Later breeders used the same system to develop animals for a particular purpose. For example, the Camargue bull which is bred only for fighting.



Goat



Camargue bull

### Crop rotation

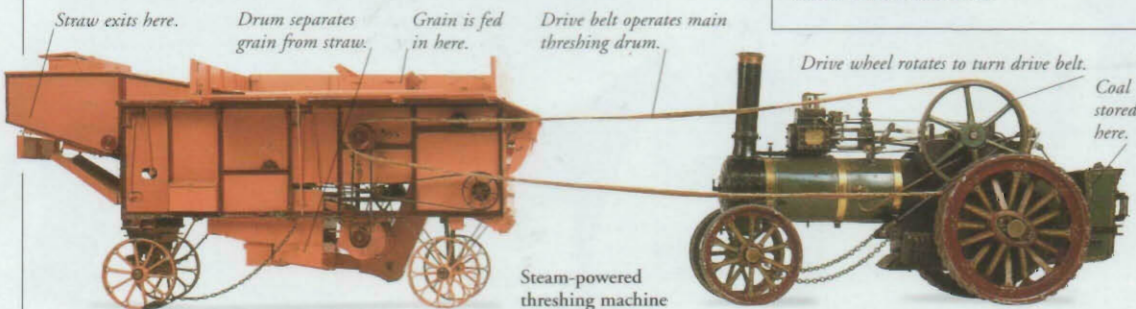
During the Agricultural Revolution, farmers found that if they grew certain crops, such as turnips, clover, barley, and wheat in successive years, they did not need to let the land lie fallow for a year. Root crops, such as turnips, improved the soil, and therefore the quality of the next harvest.



Turnips and wheat

### New farm machinery

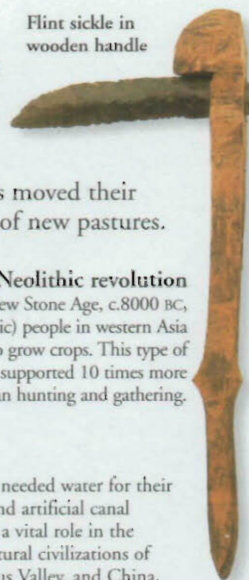
Machines, such as the thresher (formulated in 1786 by Scots inventor Andrew Meikle), eased workloads and improved productivity. Threshers, which separated the grain from the straw, became more effective after 1850 when farm workers attached steam engines to power them.



## Early farmers

The first farmers tamed wild animals, kept them in herds, and used them for meat, milk, skins, and wool. By contrast, nomadic herders moved their animals constantly in search of new pastures.

Flint sickle in wooden handle



Rice farming

### Neolithic revolution

After the New Stone Age, c.8000 BC, (Neolithic) people in western Asia began to grow crops. This type of farming supported 10 times more people than hunting and gathering.

### Irrigation

Early farmers needed water for their crops. Rivers and artificial canal systems played a vital role in the ancient agricultural civilizations of Egypt, the Indus Valley, and China.

## Medieval farming

Farmers in medieval Europe divided the land around their village into three fields. Each family had one 12-hectare strip of land in each field. Everyone followed the same three-year farming cycle: one field was left fallow (unused) each year to restore the soil's nutrients, and the other two grew barley, oats, rye, or wheat.

### Enclosures

From the 1500s, English landowners enclosed common land with fences, ditches or hedges, to turn it into private property. As a result, the co-operative medieval system of farming gave way to a system of private ownership where landowners made all the decisions about what to farm.



Book of Hours, 1416

## Charles "Turnip" Townshend

A main forerunner of the Agricultural Revolution, Viscount Townshend (1674–1738) retired from a brilliant career in politics to concentrate on farming. He popularized a four-course rotation of crops, and pioneered "marling" (using limey clay as fertilizer). His widespread cultivation of the turnip – as a fodder crop to keep animals fed during the winter – earned him his nickname.



## Green Revolution

In the 1960s, a Green Revolution took place. New "high-yield" crop varieties were developed to increase wheat and rice production, particularly in highly populated countries such as India, and China. Critics claimed this process damaged the environment through overuse of fertilizer and concentration on only a few species. Recently farmers have been rediscovering traditional farming methods and using organic fertilizers and insecticides.



Seaweed, an organic fertilizer

FIND OUT MORE

BRONZE AGE

CHINA, HISTORY OF

EGYPT, ANCIENT

EUROPE, MEDIEVAL

FARMING

INDUSTRIAL REVOLUTION

INVENTIONS

KHMER EMPIRE

STONE AGE

SUMERIANS